

How does partisan type influence affective polarization?*

Conceptualization, measurement, and scope conditions in 25 European democracies

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DRAFT: Work in progress. Please do not cite or circulate without the author's permission. Current status: framing and roadmap notes.

We distinguish between **explicit identifiers**, **implicit partisans (vote-based)**, and **non-partisans**.

The core claim of the paper is that *observed levels and cross-national patterns of affective polarization (AP) depend systematically on how partisanship and polarization are conceptualized and measured* in multi-party systems.

1 Data and empirical domain

We use data from Hahm, Hilpert, and König (2024), collected in **2019** in 25 European democracies (all EU member states at the time except Luxembourg and Malta, plus the UK).

The dataset has been used to study partyism and coalition partnership dynamics (e.g., APSR article based on the same project), but our contribution differs in focus:

*Space for acknowledgements. Wordcount: .

we center on **conceptualization, measurement, and comparative scope conditions of affective polarization** rather than coalition alignment or generalized partyism.

Temporal limitation:

- Data stem from a two cross-sectional waves (2019).
- Findings do not capture post-2019 developments (e.g., pandemic politics, recent electoral realignments).

2 Framing: Conceptual proliferation in comparative AP research

Affective polarization has become central in political science and is increasingly studied in **comparative multi-party systems**. This expansion raises conceptual and methodological questions.

Recent work distinguishes between:

- **Ideological vs. ideational polarization**
- **Identity-based vs. attitude-based affective polarization**
- **Targets of affect** ([Areal and Harteveld 2024](#); [Röllicke 2023](#); [Reiljan et al. 2024](#)):
 - Vertical/political (toward political elites (LAP) / parties (PAP))
 - Horizontal/social (toward fellow citizens / partisans)

In multi-party systems, additional choices matter:

- **Ingroup identification:** explicit identification vs. vote intention/choice

- **Outgroup construction:** all parties vs. most distant party
- **Weighting by party size**
- Inclusion (or exclusion) of **non-partisans**

Comparative research has rarely examined how these design choices affect:

- the magnitude of AP,
- cross-country rankings,
- and substantive inferences about democratic implications.

This is our entry point.

3 Analytical separation of components

We proceed in three conceptually distinct steps:

1. **Thermometer-based AP (attitudinal; vertical; party-targeted)**

→ Used to illustrate how operationalization choices affect comparative inference in multi-party systems.

2. **Behavioral AP (conjoint; horizontal; citizen-targeted)**

→ Estimated via solidarity and trust games.

→ Presented as behavioral consequences of partisan boundaries.

3. **Comparative scope and composition**

→ How the distribution of partisan types across 25 democracies conditions aggregate AP.

We explicitly separate thermometer and game results to avoid conflating:

- concept,
- measurement,
- and behavioral manifestation.

4 Part I – Thermometer-based affective polarization

This section uses *only party-targeted thermometer items*.

Key limitation:

- No direct measure of affect toward fellow citizens.
- Thus: vertical (party) rather than horizontal (citizen) AP.

4.1 Roadmap for this section

We demonstrate how AP estimates change depending on:

- Explicit vs. implicit ingroup definition
- Inclusion vs. exclusion of non-partisans
- Alternative aggregation and weighting strategies

Main goal: Show that in multi-party systems, the *choice of operationalization* meaningfully affects:

- effect sizes,
- country rankings,

- dispersion across countries.

This directly addresses open questions about the transferability of U.S.-centric AP concepts to fragmented party systems.

4.2 Comparative composition of partisan types (idea notes)

The share of:

- explicit identifiers,
- implicit (vote-based) partisans,
- non-partisans,

varies substantially across countries.

Loose idea for theoretical anchoring:

- Link variation to classic work on partisan dealignment in Europe
- Consider long-term differences in party system institutionalization and partisan attachment
- Connect to literature on party identification decline and electoral volatility in Europe.

Potential implication: Countries with weak partisan identities may mechanically display lower identity-based AP but not necessarily lower behavioral discrimination.

This section remains exploratory and descriptive but could situate our compositional findings in broader comparative political culture debates.

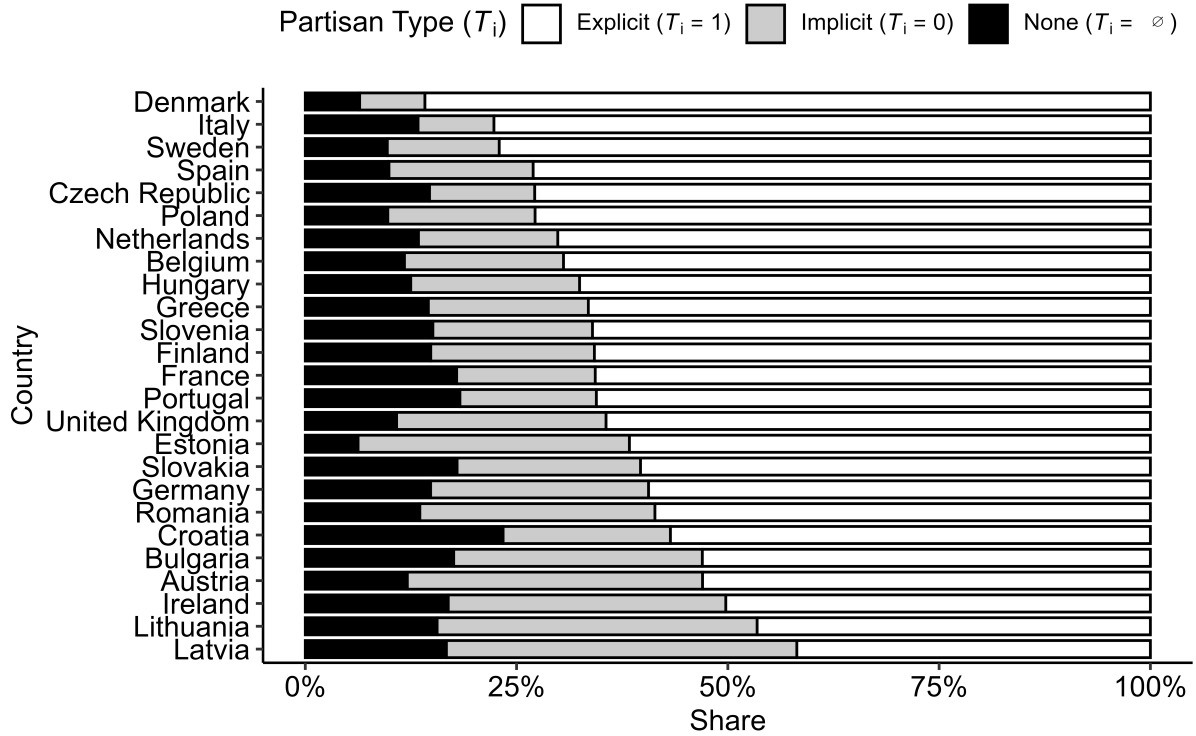


Figure 1: Distribution of partisan types, by country. Stacked horizontal bars show the within-country share (%) of three partisan types: explicit partisans (respondents who reported a subjective attachment to a party, $T_i = 1$), implicit partisans (respondents who reported no attachment but did report a vote preference or intention, $T_i = 0$), and respondents who reported neither (none, $T_i = \emptyset$). Percentages sum to 100% within each country, with country samples containing about 1,100 respondents each (detailed numbers are reported in appendix section X).

Source: [Code Notebook 3.1](#)

5 Part II – Behavioral polarization as consequences

We present the conjoint results separately from thermometer analyses.

Conceptual shift:

- From **attitudinal differentiation toward parties (vertical)**

to

- **Behavioral discrimination toward fellow citizens (horizontal).**

Outcomes:

- Solidarity allocations (dictator game logic)
- Trust allocations (trust game logic)

Here, affective polarization manifests as:

- Differential allocation toward co-partisans vs. out-partisans.

We treat these as **behavioral consequences of partisan boundaries**, rather than as alternative scaling of thermometer AP.

Open conceptual question: To what extent do attitudinal (vertical) and behavioral (horizontal) AP align within and across countries?

Possible empirical extension:

- Estimate correlation between country-level attitudinal AP and behavioral AP (posterior correlation).

6 Muslimhood, partisan interaction, and sorting

(targeted extension)

The religion attribute in the conjoint is **uniformly randomized** across:

- Muslim
- Christian

- Non-religious

Thus, estimates assume **no religious sorting** in exposure.

Exploratory results (note to be formalized):

- Muslim co-partisans receive fewer tokens than Christian or non-religious co-partisans.
- Muslim out-partisans receive fewer tokens than Christian or non-religious out-partisans.
- The penalty is larger within the co-partisan condition than within the out-partisan condition.
- Interaction effects are therefore **asymmetric**, not uniform across partisan categories.

Two implications:

1. **Theoretical:**

One should not assume symmetric sorting or interaction effects between partisan and religious identities.

Minority attributes may condition in-group favoritism differently than out-group derogation.

2. **External validity:**

Because religion is uniformly distributed by design, real-world exposure patterns (where Muslim citizens are not evenly distributed across partisan categories) are not reflected.

Possible extension:

- Incorporate prior information about realistic joint distributions of religion $\times$ partisanship to simulate more externally valid scenarios.
- Use the uniform design as a benchmark (“no-sorting counterfactual”) against which realistic sorting patterns could be contrasted.

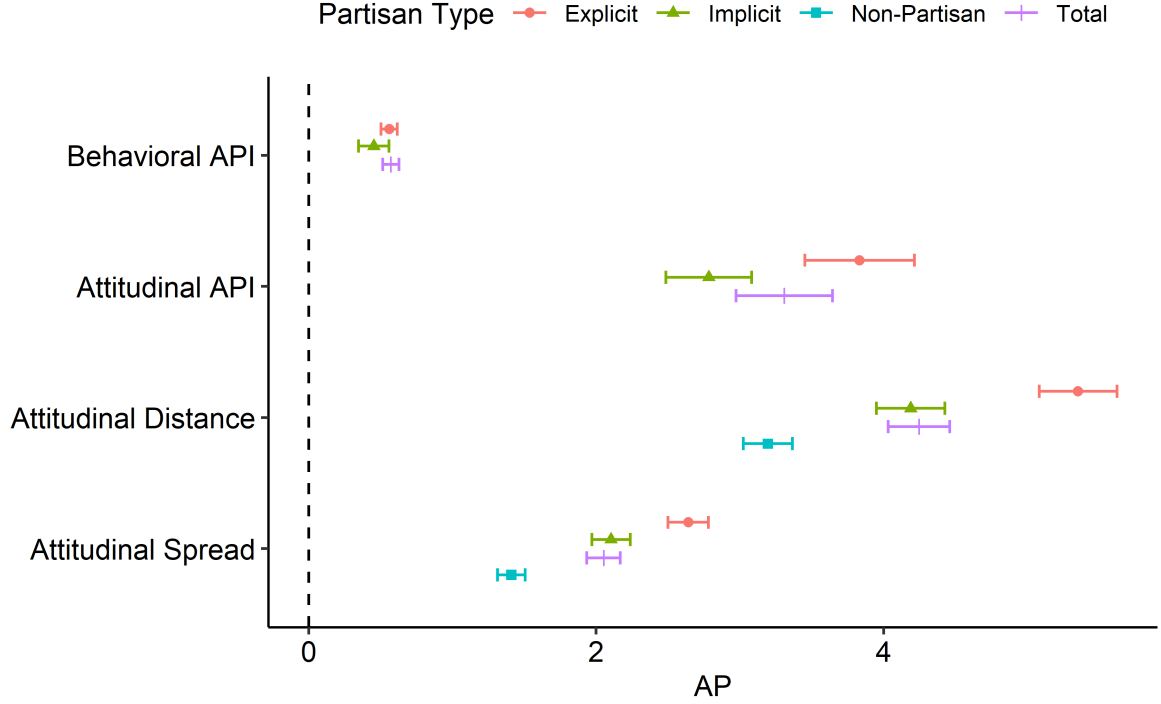


Figure 2: Comparison of Behavioral and Attitudinal Affective Polarization in the EU25. This figure displays aggregated affective polarization (AP) scores across four different operationalizations, categorized by partisan attachment type. Behavioral API (Token) measures the difference in expected token allocations between co-partisans and out-partisans in a conjoint game. Attitudinal API represents Reiljan (2020)’s index, calculated as the distance between in-group and average out-group thermometer scores. Attitudinal Distance and Spread follow Wagner (2021) metrics, capturing the root mean square distance from the most-liked party and the overall standard deviation of party evaluations, respectively. All estimates are weighted by party vote shares within each country to reflect national party system compositions and then averaged across 25 European countries. To ensure comparability, attitudinal thermometer scores (originally 0–100) have been rescaled to a 0–10 range to match the behavioral token scale. Explicit partisans are those reporting a psychological attachment to a party; Implicit partisans are those denying attachment but reporting a vote choice; Total represents all individuals with a partisan anchor; and Non-Partisans represent respondents without a reported party anchor. Error bars indicate 95% confidence intervals based on cross-national variance.

Source: [Code Notebook 3.2](#)

7 Modeling strategy (note)

Planned approach:

- Hierarchical (partial pooling) estimation for country-level quantities.
- EU-level benchmarks derived via marginalization over country-level posteriors.
- Report standardized or scale-relative effects (thermometer vs. token scales not directly comparable).

Potential extension:

- Estimate posterior correlation between country-level attitudinal AP and behavioral AP.
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8 Limitations (draft notes)

1. Party-targeted thermometers only

→ No direct citizen-targeted affect measure in the attitudinal section.

2. Weighting by party size

Assumes encounter probability proportional to electoral share.

Social visibility may violate this (e.g., radical challenger parties).

3. Uniform conjoint distribution

No endogenous religious sorting; real-world joint distributions may differ.

4. Cross-sectional design (2019)

Results capture a specific pre-pandemic political context.

No dynamic inference about temporal change.

9 Contribution (working formulation)

In comparative multi-party systems:

- Affective polarization is not a single quantity.
- Its magnitude and cross-national configuration depend on:
 - ingroup definition,
 - inclusion of non-partisans,
 - aggregation rules,
 - and whether polarization is conceptualized vertically or horizontally.

Rather than asking only “*How polarized are European democracies?*”,
we ask:

How does conceptualization reshape what, and even who, we observe as polarized in multi-party contexts?

10 References

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11 Appendix

11.1 Sample descriptives

Table 1: Sample composition by country. Numbers denote respondents.

Country	N	Percent
Austria	1277	0.04
Belgium	1305	0.04
Bulgaria	982	0.03
Croatia	1240	0.04
Czech Republic	1135	0.04
Denmark	1200	0.04

Table 1: Sample composition by country. Numbers denote respondents.

Country	N	Percent
Estonia	944	0.03
Finland	1160	0.04
France	1156	0.04
Germany	1188	0.04
Greece	1161	0.04
Hungary	986	0.03
Ireland	1061	0.04
Italy	1172	0.04
Latvia	1148	0.04
Lithuania	1265	0.04
Netherlands	1221	0.04
Poland	1198	0.04
Portugal	1187	0.04
Romania	1480	0.05
Slovakia	1297	0.04
Slovenia	1135	0.04
Spain	1396	0.05
Sweden	1254	0.04
United Kingdom	1279	0.04
Total	29827	0.99

Source: [Code Notebook 3.1](#)

Table 2: Sample composition by country and gender. Numbers denote respondents.

Country	Male	Female	Other
Austria	645	630	2
Belgium	729	574	2
Bulgaria	463	518	1
Croatia	545	694	1
Czech Republic	515	618	2
Denmark	690	508	2
Estonia	331	611	2
Finland	586	567	7
France	562	594	0
Germany	587	597	4
Greece	588	572	1
Hungary	493	492	1
Ireland	481	577	3
Italy	603	569	0
Latvia	415	733	0
Lithuania	462	803	0
Netherlands	642	577	2
Poland	540	658	0
Portugal	593	593	1
Romania	837	641	2
Slovakia	550	746	1
Slovenia	569	566	0

Table 2: Sample composition by country and gender. Numbers denote respondents.

Country	Male	Female	Other
Spain	677	718	1
Sweden	648	602	4
United Kingdom	635	641	3
Total	14386	15399	42

Source: [Code Notebook 3.1](#)

Table 3: Sample composition by country and age group. Numbers denote respondents.

Country	18 to 25	26 to 35	36 to 45	46 to 55	56 to 65	66 to 75	> 75
Austria	144	177	249	263	286	142	0
Belgium	197	132	160	235	333	239	3
Bulgaria	57	195	231	250	212	33	0
Croatia	119	251	272	331	205	47	0
Czech Republic	88	187	227	219	281	126	0
Denmark	132	134	139	208	321	249	4
Estonia	56	168	164	283	265	7	0
Finland	125	178	210	242	259	137	1
France	123	176	242	267	279	51	0
Germany	125	184	200	240	313	117	0
Greece	77	202	376	318	136	34	0
Hungary	51	175	196	166	273	117	1
Ireland	128	216	223	187	169	120	0

Table 3: Sample composition by country and age group. Numbers denote respondents.

Country	18 to 25	26 to 35	36 to 45	46 to 55	56 to 65	66 to 75	> 75
Italy	104	196	264	195	294	98	2
Latvia	78	251	231	338	239	6	0
Lithuania	223	311	257	250	212	2	0
Netherlands	149	126	161	234	340	194	3
Poland	200	342	222	187	196	42	0
Portugal	112	260	289	231	218	67	1
Romania	128	339	373	347	202	65	0
Slovakia	139	223	282	290	250	108	1
Slovenia	97	186	246	284	234	72	0
Spain	125	293	355	305	228	66	1
Sweden	124	165	156	234	297	261	3
United Kingdom	121	184	196	234	268	250	1
Total	3022	5251	5921	6338	6310	2650	21

Source: [Code Notebook 3.1](#)

11.2 Experimental setup

Before the behavioral games, Hahm, Hilpert, and König (2024) presented respondents a short background information overview and instructions. For the dictator game, these were: *This game is played by pairs of individuals. Each pair is made up of a Player 1 and a Player 2. Each player will have some information about the other player, but you*

will not be told who the other players are during or after the experiment. The game is conducted as follows: A sum of 10 tokens will be provisionally allocated to Player 1 at the start of each round. Player 1 will then decide how much of the 10 tokens to offer to Player 2. Player 1 could give some, all, or none of the 10 tokens. Player 1 keeps all tokens not given to Player 2. Player 2 gets to keep all the tokens Player 1 offers. You will play this game three times with three different people. In the trust game, the provided information and instruction were: This game is played by pairs of individuals. Each pair is made up of a Player 1 and a Player 2. Each player will have some information about the other player, but you will not be told who the other players are during or after the experiment. Each player will receive 10 tokens. Player 1 then has the opportunity to give a portion of his or her 10 tokens to Player 2. Player 1 could give some, all, or none of the 10 tokens. Whatever amount Player 1 decides to give to Player 2 will be tripled before it is passed on to Player 2. Player 2 then has the option of returning any portion of this tripled amount to Player 1. Then, the game is over. Player 1 receives whatever he or she keeps from the original 10 tokens, plus anything returned to him or her by Player 2. Player 2 receives their original 10 tokens, plus whatever he or she keeps after returning any portion of the tripled amount to Player 1. You will play this game three times, with three different people. The more tokens you obtain, the more successful you will be.

In both games respondents were shown a tabular overview of Player 2 after the instructions. Figure 3 shows an example of such a profile along with the interface respondents were provided to assign the 10 tokens. Each round, a new profile was displayed to respondents.

	Player 2
Nationality	United Kingdom
Age	18
Party Affiliation	Labour Party (Labour)
Gender	Female
Religion	Muslim
Social Class	Middle Class

So put the number of tokens you wish to keep in the box labeled "Player 1." Put the tokens you wish to go to Player 2 in the box labeled "Player 2."

Player 1 (You)	0	Token(s)
Player 2	0	Token(s)
Total	0	Token(s)

Figure 3: Example of potential co-player profile.

11.3 Distribution of Y

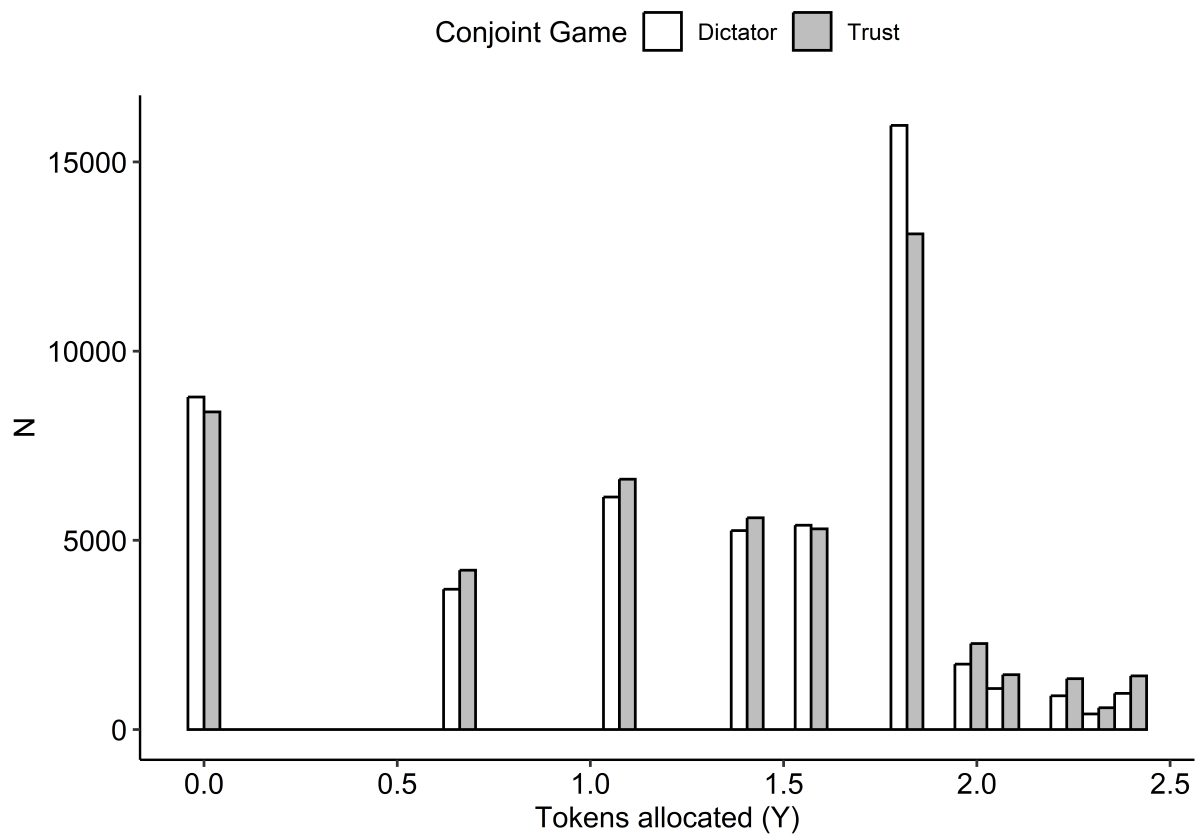


Figure 4: Distribution of token allocation (Y) by game. Dictator game: $Mean = 3.41$, $median = 4$, $SD = 2.35$. Trust game: $Mean = 3.48$, $median = 4$, $SD = 2.49$

Source: [Code Notebook 3.1](#)

11.4 Distribution of T and R

Table 4

der_partisan_type	None	Co	Out
0	5123	1948	18465
1	14898	30820	29366

Source: [Code Notebook 3.1](#)

11.5 Distribution of Covariates by T

Table 5

	0	1
Variable	N = 25,536 ¹	N = 75,084 ¹
q_lrpos2_z	-0.08 (-0.45, 0.29)	-0.08 (-0.82, 0.66)
q_eupos2_z	0.08 (-0.68, 0.46)	0.08 (-0.68, 0.84)
q_econ_nativism_z	0.15 (-1.03, 0.74)	0.15 (-1.03, 0.74)
q_cult_nativism_z	0.07 (-1.03, 0.62)	0.07 (-1.03, 0.62)
q_satis_demo_country_z	0.30 (-0.81, 1.40)	0.30 (-0.81, 0.30)
q_understand_nat_pol_z	0.12 (-0.65, 0.12)	0.12 (-0.65, 0.90)
q_understand_eu_pol_z	0.22 (-0.50, 0.22)	0.22 (-0.50, 0.94)
q_parties_harm_z	0.25 (-0.38, 0.88)	0.25 (-0.38, 0.88)
q_officials_talk_action_z	0.41 (-0.33, 1.15)	0.41 (-0.33, 1.15)
q_politics_good_evil_z	-0.14 (-0.76, 0.48)	-0.14 (-0.76, 0.48)
q_people_unaware_z	0.40 (-0.81, 1.00)	-0.20 (-0.81, 1.00)
q_leaders_educated_z	0.39 (-0.32, 1.10)	0.39 (-1.03, 1.10)
q_expert_decisions_z	0.16 (-0.49, 0.80)	0.16 (-0.49, 0.80)
q_listen_other_groups_z	0.18 (-0.74, 1.10)	0.18 (-0.74, 1.10)
q_democracy_compromise_z	-0.29 (-0.29, 0.57)	-0.29 (-0.29, 0.57)
q_interest_pol_country_z	0.06 (-0.60, 0.72)	0.06 (-0.60, 0.72)
q_interest_pol_eu_z	-0.28 (-0.96, 0.39)	0.39 (-0.28, 1.06)
q_eval_finance_household_z	0.01 (-0.99, 1.00)	0.01 (-0.99, 1.00)
q_eval_job_z	0.11 (-0.80, 1.03)	0.11 (-0.80, 0.11)
q_eval_econ_country_z	-0.14 (-1.03, 0.76)	-0.14 (-1.03, 0.76)
q_eval_econ_eur_z	0.07 (-0.94, 1.09)	0.07 (-0.94, 1.09)

Table 5

	0	1
Variable	N = 25,536 ¹	N = 75,084 ¹
q_risk_taking_z	0.11 (-0.56, 0.78)	0.11 (-0.56, 0.78)
q_future_discount_z	-0.17 (-0.84, 0.50)	-0.17 (-0.84, 0.50)
q_edu_z	-0.08 (-0.73, 0.57)	-0.08 (-0.73, 0.57)
q_age_z	-0.11 (-0.92, 0.64)	0.09 (-0.79, 0.91)
q_religion_en		
catholic	8,606 (34%)	27,379 (36%)
no religion	9,462 (37%)	25,678 (34%)
protstnt	1,881 (7.4%)	7,570 (10%)
other religion	5,470 (21%)	13,791 (18%)
muslim	114 (0.4%)	664 (0.9%)
q_perc_class		
Working class	5,307 (22%)	15,198 (21%)
Lower middle class	4,866 (20%)	13,924 (19%)
Middle class	12,060 (49%)	35,019 (48%)
Upper middle class	2,055 (8.4%)	7,622 (10%)
Upper class	191 (0.8%)	1,310 (1.8%)
q_rural_urban		
Rural area or village	5,819 (23%)	17,093 (23%)

Table 5

	0	1
Variable	N = 25,536 ¹	N = 75,084 ¹
Small or middle sized town	9,069 (36%)	28,418 (38%)
Large town	10,573 (42%)	29,298 (39%)
q_gender		
Male	10,939 (43%)	39,456 (53%)
Female	14,565 (57%)	35,514 (47%)
Other	32 (0.1%)	114 (0.2%)
¹ Median (Q1, Q3); n (%)		

Source: [Code Notebook 3.1](#)

11.6 Robustness